

Bumble

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“Every cloud has a silver lining”: Bumble, the beginning

Whitney Wolfe Herd



Founded in 2014 by Whitney Wolfe Herd , Bumble, **a dating and networking app where women make the first move**, matches, and connect for romance, friendship, or business.



The Problem

In 2014, Whitney Wolfe Herd faced severe online abuse following her sexual harassment lawsuit against Tinder.

The Opportunity

The Vision

After her experience with online abuse, she intended to create a female focused platform social network called “merci”, exclusively for women to interact with each other and encourage kindness.

The Pivot

Badoo founder backed the idea with capital & tech to target dating apps instead.

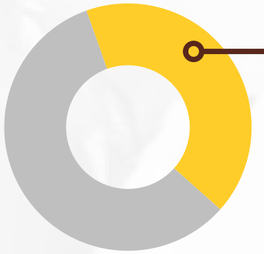
Wolfe Herd linked her female focused idea and Andreev’s offer to create Bumble.

The Pain Point

Traditional dating platforms left women overwhelmed by unsolicited messages and growing safety concerns.

Pre - 2014 data

Women were 2.5 Times more likely than men to experience harassment on early dating apps (42% vs. 17%)



42%

of female online daters reported harassing or uncomfortable contact

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Women taking a stand in a man's world

A Clear Business Model Position: Feminists Against Misogyny

WHY "BUMBLE" ?

Dating apps had solved matching but not safety and control of the interaction especially for women. In bumble, women can have more control over when and whether contact happens, which removed the harassment that was driving women away.

CONCEPT

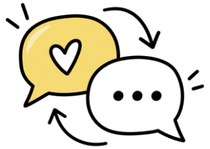
a women-first dating app designed to make online dating feel safer and more respectful.



Women make the first move



Safety and respect



Active connections

BUSINESS MODEL

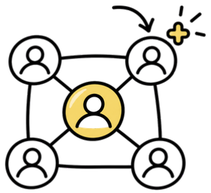
Freemium model : basic matching is free, then users pay for extra dating features



Subscriptions

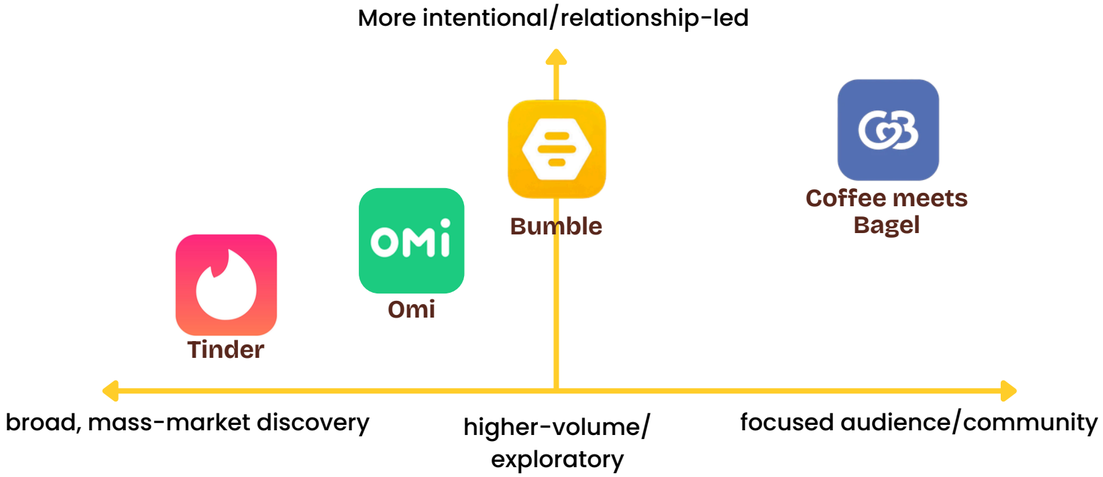


In-app purchases



Network effect

Competitor Analysis Chart



Risk Aversion

Unwanted messages

In heterosexual matches, women send the first message.

Stranger harassment

Users can block and report inappropriate behavior.

Fear of rejection

Messaging starts only after a mutual match.

Wasting time

The 24-hour message limit encourages conversations.

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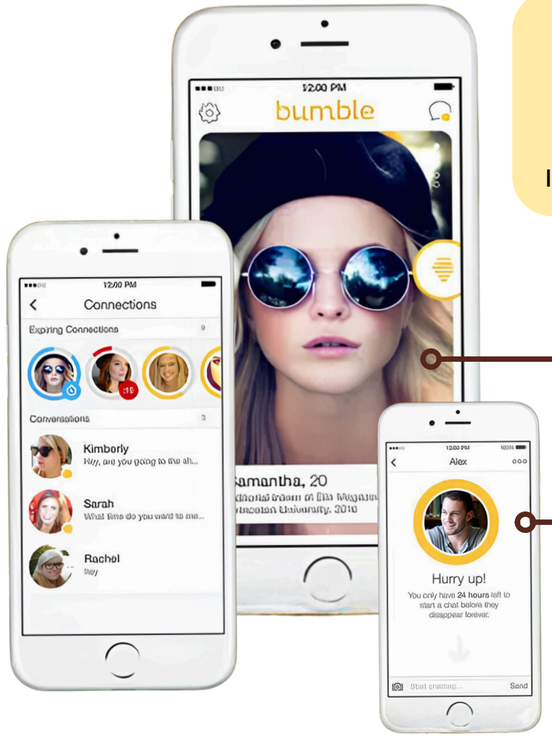
Bumble's Evolution Application UX/UI :
From Women-First Matching to Safer, More Intentional Dating

Original Version
(Launch in 2014)

The most important part of Bumble's original user interface was the post-match messaging screen with its 24-hour countdown.

Current Version
(2026 Updates)

It later expanded into friendship and networking, added monetization and safety features, and adapted to dating fatigue and user feedback.



Safety
To open an account, Bumble required a real profile and information or need to be linked with facebook account.

competitors application UI

Tinder
swipe right match, men make a move first

Key feature

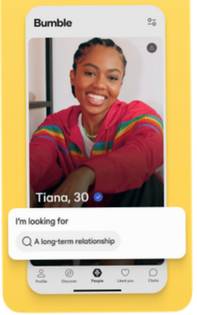
Mutual swipe matching
Both people had to swipe right before they could match.

Women made the first move
In heterosexual matches, only the woman send the first message (24-hour time limit)

Same - gender matches
being inclusive of people of all genders and sexual orientations.

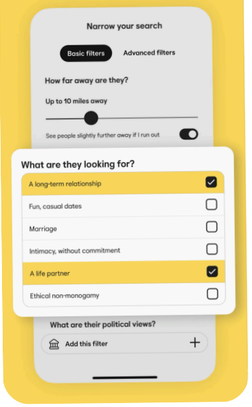
It removed the rule that women had to be the one to message first.

Kick things off with clarity

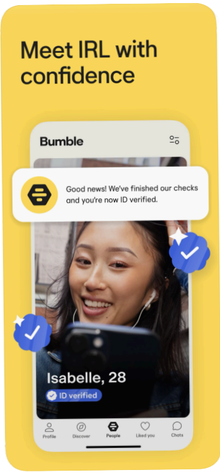


- AI Profile Guidance
- Discover
- Safety tools
- 72 hours to reply

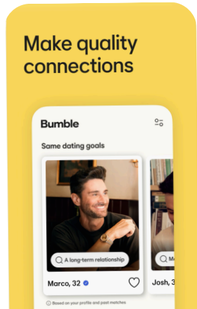
Filter for what truly matters



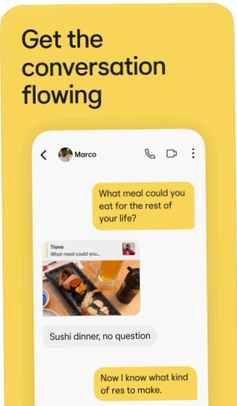
Meet IRL with confidence



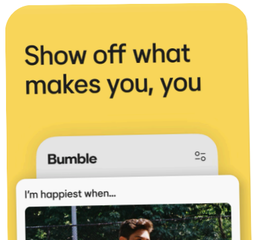
Make quality connections



Get the conversation flowing



Show off what makes you, you



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Bumble's first 100 users were not acquired as 100 isolated downloads, they targeting a connected campus community.

1

Wolfe Herd introduced the app directly to sororities using a message to encourage women

Recruit women first at SMU



2

Recruit the other side immediately

After gaining female users, the team targeted fraternity houses to join with direct campus outreach and giveaways. (solved chicken and egg problem)



3

introduced the app within the same campus and social network increased the likelihood

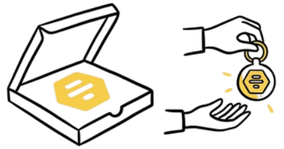
Create local marketplace density



4

How they encourage new users

They personally visited sororities and fraternities and used low cost tactics such as pizza, cookies, and direct pitches.



5

Bumble used general campus-based growth approach, they expanded beyond SMU to another university.

Replicate the campus playbook



Whitney Wolfe Herd had already gained experience acquiring the first 100 users for a leading dating app, Tinder. This time, she chose to target the same group of people, but with a different approach.

6958091056 Laphadrada Phadermkul

Bumble hit its first 100,000 downloads within its first month of launch in December 2014.

1. **Dec 2014**
   Soft-launched
   Bumble's early growth came from focusing on college campuses to reach potential users

2. **The Sorority Connection**
   Campus Ground Game reach first 100 user
   Bumble then use the success of one campus to build awareness, expand and aquire more customers.

3. **Jan 2015 Month 1 After launch they reach 100k users**
   Replicate same strategy and power of "word of mouth"
   Bumble stood out by giving women control over starting conversations in heterosexual matches. This attracted women, whose presence then drew men to the app.

4. **May 2015**
   500K Users
   This strategy helped Bumble **grow organically**

What we learn?
Our Key Take Away



Product Market fit
Solve a clear user need and focus on a specific community before expanding.



Strategic Partnership
Work with trusted partners to reach the right users and build credibility.



Brand Identity as a Moat
Turn a clear mission into a distinctive brand that builds loyalty and is hard to copy.

Scale Up
Strategic Expansion & Brand Ecosystem

New connection modes
Launched Bumble BFF and Bumble Bizz to expand from dating into friendship and professional networking, broadening its target market.

Localize to Scale
Bumble used Apple Ads to tailor keywords, audience targeting, and ad creative by country, improving international user acquisition and reengagement.

Brand extensions
Bumble developed content, merchandise, events, and physical experiences such as Bumble Brew to strengthen its brand and support real-world connections.

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